DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Is the Human Body a Map of God's Ways?

Daat Tevunot §80

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §80 (first part)
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 2 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

The class began on page 178 of the English. In this section we have learned that the body comes from hester, God's concealment, and the soul from hearah, His illumination. The more a person invests in his body, the more he invests in concealment. A young child, whose mind is not yet developed, is ruled by his body: "you can't make a child wait to eat". As the mind grows, a person can understand more.

§80: body and soul as a demonstration

The Sekhel now goes further. It is not only that the body happens to come from concealment and the soul from illumination. God decreed that this should be so, in order to demonstrate His two modes through them. The body, in its nature and its parts, displays the mode of concealment; the soul displays the mode of illumination. That, the Rabbi explained, is the meaning of "Let us make man in Our image": in man we can see something of how God acts. The human being is a microcosm of God's modes in this world.

The body always has to die

The body is dark. Even at its greatest refinement in this world, it must separate from the soul, because the soul is precious and comes from God's illumination, while the body comes from concealment. There will always be that difference.

Asked about those who went up alive, the Rabbi said they too had to die in some way, though much less of a death than usual. Everyone dies in the end, as Hazal say even of the four who died only because of the serpent's counsel.

Many parts and one

The Ramhal's next point: the body has many organs and limbs. The eye sees and does not hear; the ear hears and does not see. The soul is one and does not have these divisions. Material things are always composites.

The Rabbi linked this to what they learned many times in Derech Hashem: perfection is one. There is no more or less in perfection; it is whole, which is what shelemut means. When God

chooses not to act with that wholeness, in order to reward and punish, He acts through many different modes, and concealment always comes in parts. So He made man with many parts, each representing a different aspect of His conduct.

For example, the eye corresponds to God's hashgahah, His watching over everything. The ear: as the Mishnah says, "know what is above you, an eye that sees and an ear that hears". The mouth corresponds to God's speech, how He communicates with His prophets. The body has a right and a left, with everything doubled, just as God's traits come in pairs: kindness and judgment, inclining to merit on the right and to guilt on the left. Even after concealing Himself, His modes can still be seen.

The Ramhal's hidden Kabbalah

The Rabbi pointed out what the Ramhal has done here. This is the doctrine of the ten sefirot, which are mapped onto the human body: keter, hokhmah and binah in the head; hesed the right arm; gevurah the left arm; tiferet the torso; nesah and hod the right and left legs; yesod and malkhut below. "This is the beauty of the Ramhal. He doesn't bring in Kabbalah to you. This is all Kabbalah." He tells it in simple words: the body, with all its parts, is hester, incompleteness, because incompleteness always comes in parts. Completeness is whole and one. The Neshamah is one; it is life itself, and it permeates the whole person.

But the soul has five parts

Mark asked how this fits with what they learned, that the soul has five parts. The Rabbi agreed this looks like a direct contradiction, since the Ramhal says plainly that the soul has no parts.

The group tried several answers. Richard suggested the levels are like spheres within spheres, or Russian dolls, each a whole in itself. Another suggested that the soul includes the animal soul and the intellect but is not divisible, while the body's parts are physically separate: if you have no ear, you cannot hear.

The Rabbi briefly reviewed the five levels from Derech Hashem: nefesh, which all animals have; ruah, speech and communication; neshamah, thought and intellect; hayah, spiritual encounters beyond the intellect; and yehidah, the highest, which very few, like Moshe, reached.

The Zohar: attributes for our sake

The Ramhal then brings the Zohar. God has many names and attributes, but they are for His creatures, not new in Him. Just as God cannot be pinned down by any name, since you cannot describe what you cannot understand, neither can the soul. The prophets perceived God as merciful, as a judge and so on, because He gave us the ability to relate to Him in this way. It does not mean He has different parts. "One part of Hashem is merciful, one part is justice": we speak like this, but His essence is beyond it.

The Rabbi then offered an answer to Mark. Perhaps the soul too is one and all encompassing, but so that we can relate to it we speak of different parts, nefesh, ruah, neshamah and so on, just as we call God Rahum and Hanun. In the end God is one and the soul is one. Mark found support in the English summary of the section (page 228), which says the soul cannot really be

described and interacts with the world only through the body. "Beautiful. That's exactly the point."

The extra soul on Shabbat

A last question: what is the neshamah yeterah, the extra soul of Shabbat, if the soul is one? The Rabbi said the Ramhal explains in Derech Hashem that nothing extra comes in from outside. On Shabbat a person is far more able to connect with the third level, the neshamah. It is "a source of power that is activating what's already within you".

Summary

- §80: God made the body and soul to demonstrate His two modes: concealment in the body, illumination in the soul.
- The body, from concealment, must always die; the soul, from illumination, is precious and lasting.
- Concealment comes in parts and perfection is one, so the body has many limbs while the soul is one. This is the doctrine of the sefirot told in simple words.
- God's attributes are for our sake; in the same way, the five levels of the soul may be names that let us relate to a soul that is really one.
- The extra soul of Shabbat activates what is already within us.

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